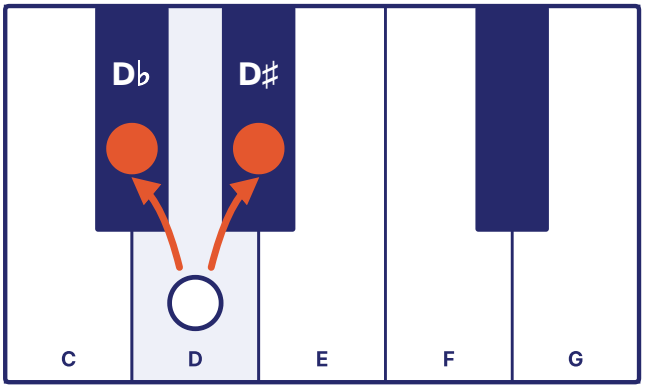
PART I · PITCH · 5

# Sharps, flats and naturals

A sharp, flat or natural in front of a note (an **accidental**) nudges it, usually by a semitone. **Sharp**: one key right, usually black. **Flat**: one key left.

THE SECRET

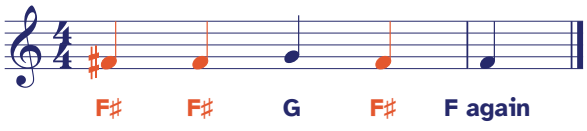
**Sharp: the very next key to the right. Flat: the very next key to the left.**



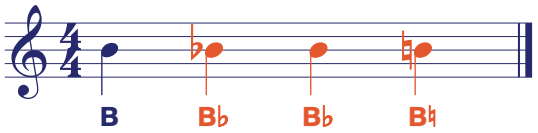

♯ one key right · ♭ one key left

| SIGN | NAME | WHAT IT DOES | FIRST MET |
|---|---|---|---|
| ♯ | sharp | raises a note by a semitone | Level 0 |
| ♭ | flat | lowers a note by a semitone | Level 0 |
| ♮ | natural | cancels a sharp or flat | Level ½ |
| 𝄪 | double sharp | raises by two semitones | Level 4 |
| 𝄫 | double flat | lowers by two semitones | Level 4 |

## Sharp till the bar line




The sharp still counts later in the bar; after the bar line, F is F again.




A natural cancels the flat for the rest of the bar.

**Only that line or space.** A sharp on the F in the first space does not change the F an octave higher.

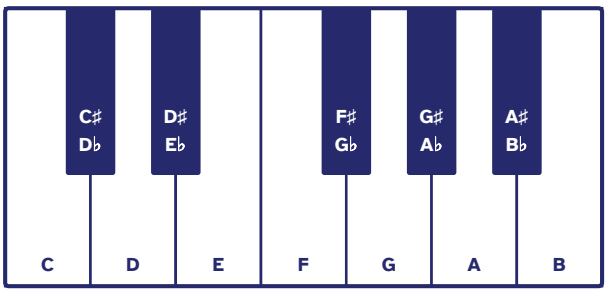
**A tie carries it on.** A note tied across the bar line keeps its accidental.

**Reminders.** A courtesy accidental, sometimes in brackets, just reminds you after a bar line.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED

## One key, two names

Every black key has two names: the key between F and G is both **F♯** and **G♭**. Notes that sound the same but are written differently are **enharmonic**. White keys can have sharp or flat names too: **E♯** is F, **C♭** is B.




EXAMPLE

### One key, two names




1. **The first bar:** F♯, then G♭.
2. **Find them:** both are the black key between F and G.
3. **The last bar:** no black key sits above E, so E♯ is the white key F.

Same key, different names: these are **enharmonic** notes.

YOU KNOW THIS

### Für Elise (Beethoven)



E, **D♯**, E, **D♯**: a semitone down and back. The sharp is written again in the new bar, because the bar line wiped it out.

**Try it.** Play E and D♯ back and forth: the black key just left of E.

THINK OF IT A key signature is the principal's notice on the school board: it speaks to every student, every day. An accidental is a teacher stopping at one student's desk: the message is for that note only, and it lasts until the next bar line.

TRAP

- × Forgetting that an accidental lasts until the bar line.
- × Carrying an accidental into the next bar: after the bar line, the key signature rules again.

SEE ALSO
Keys and key signatures p. 59

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 3 · Online: Library › Signs